

COLONS

Introducing a list, a quotation, or extra information



1 What is it?

Colons (KOH-lonz)

A colon (:) is a punctuation mark used after a complete sentence to introduce something that follows — a list, a quotation, extra information, or a closely related second idea.

complete sentence + : + what it introduces

2 See it in action

A list

"I have three pets: a cat, a dog and a parrot."

Extra info

"I missed the bus: I didn't leave the house on time."

A quotation

"The teacher gave one clear reminder: 'Check your punctuation carefully.'"

Linked clauses

"Exercise is good for your health: there is no arguing with this fact."



Think about...

Before you use a colon, check that the words in front of it could stand alone as a full sentence — if they can't, you need something else.

3 More to know

Sport

"I play a few sports: swimming, football and tennis."

Emphasis

"There is only one way to plot revenge: plan carefully before you act."

FUN FACT

A colon looks like two dots stacked on top of each other — and one memory trick is to think of it as standing for the phrase 'and these are' whenever it introduces a list.

4 Why it's used

Colons help: signal to the reader that something important is coming — a list, an explanation, or a quotation — and that it's closely connected to what came just before it.

A useful trick: when a colon introduces extra information, try replacing it with the word 'because'. If the sentence still makes sense, the colon is being used correctly.



Look here!

Try swapping the colon for the word 'because' — if the sentence still makes sense, you've used the colon correctly.

5 Where you'll spot it

Before a list

A colon after a complete sentence, followed by a list of items — I have three pets: a cat, a dog and a parrot.

Before a quotation

A colon introducing someone's exact words, as long as what comes before it is a full sentence on its own.

⚠ Watch out!

The words before a colon must always be able to stand alone as a complete sentence. "I have: a cat, a dog and a parrot" is incorrect, because "I have" isn't a complete sentence on its own — the fix is "I have three pets: a cat, a dog and a parrot."

6 Quick recap

Follows a complete sentence

Introduces a list, quote, or idea

Can replace 'because'



Good spot!

A colon and a semicolon can both link two related ideas, but a colon usually introduces or explains, while a semicolon balances two equal ideas.